7 The self-serve data platform

This chapter covers

- Understanding how our MVP fits into a self-serve data platform
- Building a self-serve data platform in three iterations
- Applying platform thinking
- Exploring X as a service
- Working with the modular plane architecture

In the first part of this book, you learned all the basics of the data mesh. That included building a data mesh MVP for Messflix within a month in chapter 3. The data mesh MVP contains a minimal self-serve platform.

After Messflix starts to build data product after data product, a lot of duplication of efforts happens in terms of ingestion tooling and other data-related technologies. These data-related skills are specialized. Thus, once we start to grow the number of data products, it is time to recall an already known idea: self-serve platforms.

The purpose of a self-serve platform is to take the duplicated and specialized skills out of the many development teams and put them into one platform. Because the platform will be used by many teams, we usually strive to make it *self-serve*, meaning it retains as much of the development teams' autonomy as possible.

KEY POINT *Platforms reduce duplicate effort.* A self-serve platform is a key to the data mesh, because a lot of data mesh skills are quite specialized. Thus, a lot of duplicate effort will take place across data-producing and -consuming teams. A platform reduces these efforts, enabling them to be done once and providing them as a capability in a self-serve manner to the data-producing and -consuming teams.

This chapter focuses on exactly that: how to build a proper self-serve data platform and a handful of concepts that come in handy for doing it right the first time around. We will do so by first recalling our minimal platform from chapter 3. And then we'll improve it in three separate iterations.